ERA 10

The Civil War Begins

1861 – 1862

Fort Sumter · strategies · early battles

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

What advantages and strategies shaped the opening years of the Civil War?

KEY TERMS

Fort Sumter · Bull Run · the Anaconda Plan · Union vs. Confederate advantages

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 5.8 · AMSCO Ch. 5.8

SECTION

The War Begins

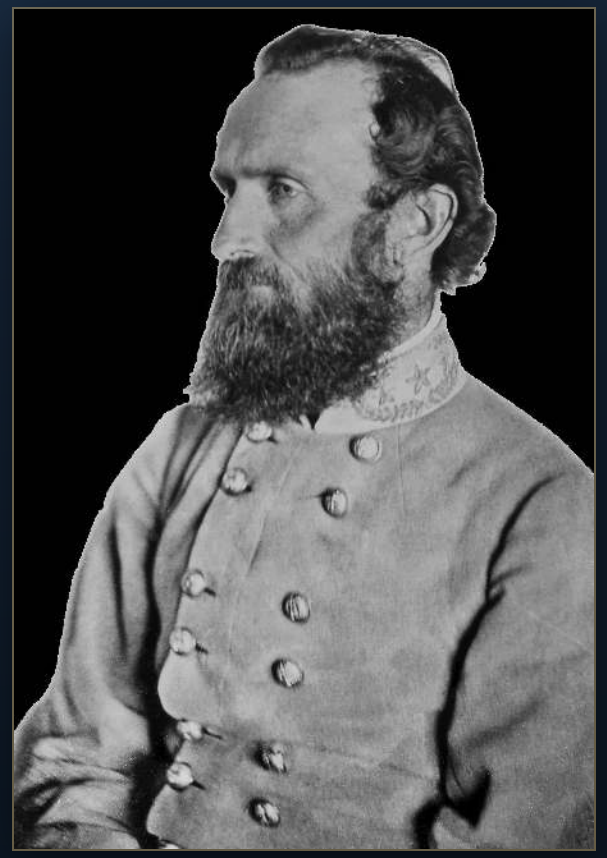
First Battle of Bull Run, 1861



- The first major battle came three months after **Fort Sumter**.
- The **Union** expected an easy win—but was driven back in chaos.
- It shattered the illusion that the war would be short.

'Stonewall' Jackson

- Confederate general Thomas Jackson stood firm 'like a **stone wall**' at **Bull Run**.
- The battle's ~1,000 casualties stunned both sides.
- Both North and South braced for a long, bloody struggle.



SECTION

The Balance of Power

North vs. South

The Union (North)

Advantages

- Far greater **industry** and manufacturing.
- A much larger population and railroad network.
- Control of the U.S. Navy for a **blockade**.

The Confederacy (South)

Advantages

- Fighting a **defensive** war on home soil.
- Strong military tradition and skilled generals.
- Hoped 'King Cotton' would win foreign allies.

SECTION

The Union's Strategy

The Anaconda Plan

I

Blockade the Coast

Seal off Southern ports to choke supplies and trade.

II

Split the South

Seize the **Mississippi River** to cut the Confederacy in two.

III

Total War

Destroy the South's capacity—and will—to fight.

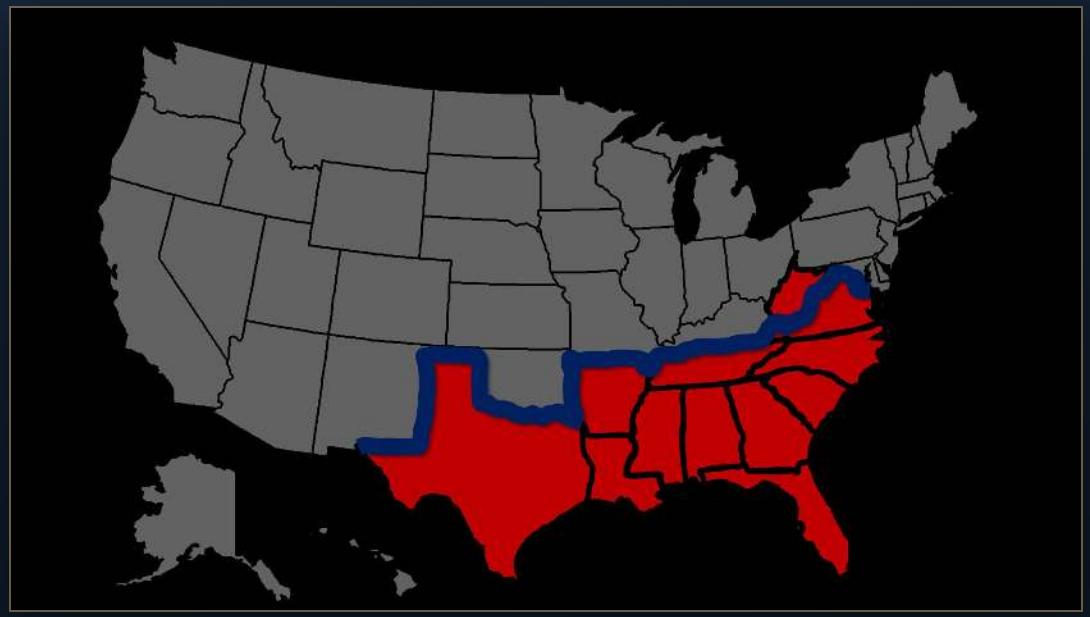
IV

Capture Richmond

Take the Confederate capital and end the rebellion.

Strangling the South

- General **Winfield Scott** designed a plan to slowly squeeze the South.
- A naval **blockade** cut off cotton exports and war supplies.
- The strategy traded quick victory for a war of attrition.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Civil War Begins

1. **Bull Run** proved the war would be long and bloody—not a quick **Union** triumph.
2. The **Union** held key advantages in industry, population, and naval power; the **Confederacy** fought a defensive war with strong generals.
3. The **Union**'s **Anaconda Plan**—**blockade**, split the South, **total war**, take Richmond—set the strategy for eventual victory.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Civil War Begins

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

COMPARISON

Compare the **advantages** of the North and the South. Which side was better positioned for a long war?

CAUSATION

Explain how the **Anaconda Plan** aimed to defeat the Confederacy over time.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

Why did the **First Battle of Bull Run** shatter hopes for a short, easy war?

Up next — **Lesson 24: Emancipation & Total War** (the turning points that won the war)